

Brussels' rising Spanish power player

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CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna back with you, and if you tuned in to our live event yesterday (more on that below), you already know this is my 100th Brussels Playbook byline since I started a year ago. Yes, I keep count: Five tally marks at a time on a piece of paper on my desk, like a prisoner on a cell wall — except I'm extremely proud of my stay.

In today's Playbook:

— Everything you need to know from our Playbook Live event — including the newest member of our newsletter family.

— The EU isn't joining Donald Trump's Board of Peace. Yet they keep showing up at each other's parties.

— Faces in the crowd: Bjoern Seibert, Magdalena Andersson, Dubravka Šuica, Benjamin Haddad, Cristina Lobillo Borrero, Vsevolod Chentsov, Teresa Ribera, Espen Barth Eide, Siegfried Murešan, Frank Furedi and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian explore Norway's Brussels dilemma: how do you shape the rules when you don't get a vote?

****A message from Google:** Google has opened Connected Cup, an AI pop-up by Google in the Brussels EU Quarter. Meet the European inventors, thinkers, and builders who are shaping this technology. Open to everyone, weekdays 08:00 to 16:00 until 16 October, with a coffee bar, product demos and events. Explore the programme .**

DRIVING THE DAY

RIBERA REDUX? As energy moves back up the agenda and Spanish politics heats up ahead of elections there, Ursula von der Leyen's latest hire is — on paper, at least — pretty much the political mirror image of Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera. Coincidence? People Max Grier and I talked to don't think so.

Enter Cristina Lobillo Borrero: The new senior adviser for the clean transition in von der Leyen's cabinet has landed in the heart of the president's inner circle, advising on the EU's energy policy as the bloc scrambles to lower costs for households and industry, strengthen its competitiveness and reduce its dependence on imported fossil fuels.

Why that hasn't gone unnoticed: Lobillo is an energy heavyweight, a longtime Commission hand described as professional, knowledgeable and friendly by those who've worked with her. She also has connections with Spain's center-right People's Party (PP), which is leading the polls ahead of the country's 2027 general election. Ribera, the Spanish commissioner responsible for a clean, just and competitive transition, hails from the country's Socialist party, currently second in the polls.

Von der Leyen brought in Lobillo to serve as a "counterweight" to Ribera, one lawmaker from the European People's Party — the European home of the PP — told Playbook, granted anonymity to speak frankly about how the party sees the civil servant. The move has also set up a direct line to Spain's center-right at the heart of the Commission, the lawmaker said.

It's no secret, the MEP argued, that Ribera and von der Leyen don't always see eye to eye on energy. Lobillo gives the Commission president her own trusted voice on the file — and ensures the topic isn't left entirely in the hands of her forthright executive vice president.

"The president's cabinet is made up of a selection of the most experienced officials in their respective fields," Commission spokesperson Paula Pinho told Playbook, adding that Lobillo was picked as "one of the most respected and senior energy officials" in the Commission.

"We have different profiles," Ribera told Playbook. Lobillo has "a long and solid technical career in the European Commission. I trust her," Ribera said, adding that the two have always had a very good relationship.

Complementary, not contradictory: Lobillo "is not there to undermine Ribera or anything of the sort; she acts following Ursula's lead," a second MEP told Playbook.

Lobillo proved particularly valuable to von der Leyen during the energy crisis and the scramble to ditch Russian gas, when she led a special task force to decouple from Russian fossil fuels, three Commission officials told Playbook. She became especially close to von der Leyen's powerful chief of staff Bjoern Seibert during that period, two said — effectively becoming the key official giving them the technical background on energy.

"She is there to implement the energetic priorities of the president," said one of the officials, adding that "with how vertical the Commission is, being in the direct line of command of von der Leyen, that makes her the most influential Spanish official in Brussels."

Madrid subplot: Lobillo has no formal ties with Spain's PP but her political origins are in working with PP heavyweight Miguel Arias Cañete — first in José María Aznar's government, later as his chief of staff when he became EU energy and climate commissioner.

Regardless, her connections mean the EU's center-right is eyeing her up as a potential key power player if the PP takes charge in Madrid next year, with the EPP lawmaker saying she is potential ministerial material back home. "If she has to defend a Spanish position, people know her and trust her at the Commission, the same in Council and Parliament," the first MEP said.

BIG AND BREAKING

EXCLUSIVE — AI ANXIETY IS SWEEPING THE GLOBE: Pluralities of adults in the U.S., Canada and Europe want to pause AI development regardless of their political leanings — and most believe there's a real risk the technology could destroy humanity, according to a new POLITICO Poll .

SÁNCHEZ TEARS INTO TRUMP: Spanish PM Pedro Sánchez, after skipping a UNGA reception with Donald Trump, took a swipe at the U.S. president on The Weekly Show with Jon Stewart — calling Trump's address to the assembly "ideological ... not backed and supported by facts and data," according to a preview clip posted to social media overnight.

Trump earlier used his UNGA speech to cast himself as a peacemaker, while also saying he was willing to "annihilate" Iran ... and rejected the idea of a global body to oversee artificial intelligence (or what he called "super intelligence").

Other leaders at the U.N. this week have been careful to stay onside with Trump — yet there is a distinct undercurrent of defiance toward Washington, my stateside colleagues report .

Also in New York last night: Canadian PM Mark Carney committed \$100 million in assistance for Palestine , shortly before meeting U.K. PM Andy Burnham and French President Emmanuel Macron to discuss a two-state solution.

LIBERTÉ, ÉGALITÉ, DÉLISTÉ: EU capitals struck a deal to remove billionaires Alisher Usmanov and Mikhail Fridman from the bloc's Russia sanctions list after a high-stakes diplomatic play by France.

POWER VACUUM: Romania's potential next prime minister, the European People's Party MEP Siegfried Mureșan, told Playbook's Gabriel Gavin that the country's political deadlock risks handing power to the far right.

CAPITAL CONNECTIONS

NEW KID ON THE BLOCK: Welcoming Brussels Playbook Capitals, POLITICO's new weekday afternoon briefing drawing on our reporting across Europe to connect the national political moves shaping the EU and its place in the world. Read the first edition here .

The fresh addition to the Playbook family was announced at POLITICO's inaugural Brussels Playbook Live event yesterday.

ICYMI: France's Europe Minister Benjamin Haddad warned about the consequences of slashing the EU's Global Europe budget after Playbook revealed Commission simulations involving cuts as high as 40% of the total, telling POLITICO's Kathryn Carlson: "Look at the consequences of the cuts of USAID. I think it's been detrimental, including, by the way, to U.S. interests."

Reports of possible cuts to Global Europe have prompted warnings from advocacy groups and MEPs about the risk of slashing EU global outreach. “Drastic cuts would be a betrayal of everything the EU stands for in the world and only mimic the short-sighted ideology behind President Trump’s USAID cuts, which have already had a devastating impact,” Renew lawmaker Barry Andrews said in a statement.

Also at our summit: Ukraine’s deputy prime minister for European and Euro-Atlantic Integration, Vsevolod Chentsov, announced that Kyiv is open to a grain truce with Russia ... Canada’s EU envoy Jonathan Wilkinson said Ottawa and Brussels will announce a comprehensive set of partnerships within the coming year — though the shape of the future relationship is still up for discussion ... Finnish EPP lawmaker Mika Aaltola said his party won’t rule out voting with the far right to deliver its policy agenda, and that the EU is weighing closer economic cooperation with the U.K. ... and Jonathan Martin, POLITICO’s U.S. politics bureau chief, told attendees that getting the White House onside isn’t about ideology — it’s about popularity.

SPOTTED ... at the Brussels Playbook Live and Back to School Party, getting the scoop from us Playbookers and podcasters: Ukraine’s Deputy Prime Minister Vsevolod Chentsov; MEPs René Repasi, Mika Aaltola, Gerben-Jan Gerbrandy, Udo Bullmann, Andreas Glück and Lukas Sieper; Poland’s Secretary of State for Foreign Affairs Ignacy Niemczycki; French Europe Minister Benjamin Haddad; Canada’s EU envoy Jonathan Wilkinson; NATO’s James Appathurai; and Axis Advisors’ Sebastian Vos ...

Plus ... ambassadors Ioannis Vrailas of Greece, Marcos Alonso of Spain, Angus Campbell of Australia and Simon Draper of New Zealand; Cefic’s Marco Mensink; GLOBSEC’s Daniel Braun; Commission spokespeople Arianna Podestà, Olof Gill and Anna-Kaisa Itkonen; Commission comms advisers Clémence Robin, Célia Dejongd, Ana Apse-Paese, Lukas Gassner, Giulia Bedini and Antoine Guéry; Vodafone’s Darren Ennis; the U.S. Mission’s Norman Thatcher Scharpf; McCourt’s Shéhérazade Semsar-de Boissésou; HP’s Maxime Bureau; OpenAI’s Olga Nowicka; Uber’s Sophie Bonnetcarrière ...

And breathe ... the Parliament’s Jüri Laas, Mina Andreeva and Delphine Colard; European Council’s Maria Tomasik; Ireland’s perm rep spokespeople Eoin Kasai Flavin and Peadar Ó hÚbáin; Belgium’s Alexandre Brecx and Sofia Smorscek; Alexandros Yennimatas from the Greek perm rep; the Indonesian embassy’s Emilia Hartuty Elisa; and POLITICO’s Jonathan Martin, John Harris, Kate Day, Annie Allen and Carrie Budoff Brown.

OSLO’S BEEN TOO SLOW

NORWEGIANS WOULD? Norway wants to rejig the way it goes about influencing EU policy — and start lobbying Brussels earlier to better protect its own interests.

The key change: Norwegian officials should start working on a proposal when it is put forward by the European Commission, rather than waiting until EU countries have given their final sign-off, according to new government proposals .

That might sound obvious to the average Playbook reader ... but it would mean a significant change in approach for Norway which, despite not being part of the EU, adopts most of the bloc’s rules due to its membership of the European Economic Area (EEA). “We are making changes that make it possible to start promoting Norwegian positions and interests earlier – that is where the real room for action lies,” Foreign Minister Espen Barth Eide said.

Areas of interest: “We will now be earlier and more active in the development of European policy, particularly in the area of industrial policy,” Trade and Industry Minister Cecilie Myrseth said. Oslo also wants closer cooperation with the EU in areas outside — or only partly covered by — the EEA agreement, including health preparedness, defense and security, competitiveness and economic security.

Long time coming: “The business community had long called for concrete measures to ensure a more proactive administration of the EEA agreement,” Anne Line Kaxrud, deputy head of international affairs at the Confederation of Norwegian Enterprise, told Mari Eccles.

But but but: Norway’s ability to influence EU policy “remains limited since its many agreements with the EU do not permit participation in the EU’s decision-making bodies. Only EU membership can change that,” said Oda Helen Sletnes, a senior adviser at the consultancy Kreab and a former Norwegian ambassador.

****From experimentation to scale: how will Europe and Spain compete in the AI era? Join transatlantic leaders at AmChamSpain Global Trends 2026 — Madrid, 6–7 October. Explore the programme****

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The U.S. is investigating Germany’s system for pricing new medicines. Why? It’s part of Donald Trump’s effort to drive down the high cost of drugs in America, which he says is effectively subsidizing lower prices in Europe. Trump has threatened to impose additional tariffs unless European prices go up. Germany is the first EU country to come under specific U.S. pressure to raise drug prices. Berlin rejects claims that its drug pricing system is an unfair trade practice.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

EU, TRUMP EVENT SWAP

STILL ON BOARD: The EU hasn’t joined Donald Trump’s Board of Peace. Yet Brussels and the board’s top officials keep turning up at each other’s events. The courtship continues at the U.N. General Assembly — another sign that Ursula von der Leyen’s parallel diplomatic track with Washington is alive and well.

Oops, she did it again: Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica — once dubbed by Playbook as “von der Leyen’s other top diplomat” — will attend a high-level Board of Peace briefing in New York today, an EU official confirmed.

On the menu: In an invitation seen by Playbook, the briefing promises an update on the Board’s “roadmap and ongoing negotiations,” its immediate priorities and projects and “the broader outlook for the next phase of our collective efforts.”

This isn’t Šuica’s first Board of Peace meeting. She also showed up for the inaugural gathering — though the Commission has been careful to stress that attending that party does not mean joining the club.

All back to mine: The board is returning the favor, with its High Representative Nikolay Mladenov attending an EU delegation event today showcasing two European waste and water projects for Gaza,

one EU official said. “We need to work together with all actors — internationally, regionally and on the ground — to create the conditions for sustainable recovery, peace and stability,” Šuica told Playbook. “This is just the beginning.”

The real diplomatic coup would be Jared Kushner, Trump’s son-in-law and peace envoy, who has been invited to the EU event. He joined an EU conference in July by video link . The State Department declined to say whether he will show up.

There’s substance behind the mingling: Some board projects could overlap with the EU’s Team Gaza initiatives, one EU official said. Nobody quite knows yet how the two tracks will fit together — but they’re increasingly trying to find out.

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

SWEDEN IS BACK: Magdalena Andersson, the Social Democrat leader now tasked with forming a government in Stockholm, wants to refocus Swedish foreign policy — and to give the EU more muscle, she tells Tim Ross.

MERZ’S WORST ENEMY: One of the problems facing Germany’s embattled Chancellor Friedrich Merz is that when things get difficult, he has a way of making them worse .

DIVIDED IN EUROPE: The EPP is splitting along national lines over what “Made in Europe” should actually mean — just as the fight over the Industrial Accelerator Act heats up.

UNPACKING THE GREENLAND DEAL: Donald Trump hailed the agreement with Greenland and Denmark as a “fantastic” deal that would give the U.S. all the control and military access it needs — but what does that mean in practice? POLITICO breaks it down .

SPOOKING THE NEIGHBORS: EU countries are worried that Britain’s plans to release thousands of prisoners early could lead to nationals being returned with little warning.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny with a gentle breeze. High of 20C.

FUREDİ’S NEXT MOVE: Frank Furedi, who last month resigned as boss of the right-wing think tank MCC Brussels , is today launching Freedom and Sovereignty Initiative Europe, which describes itself as “a fully independent think tank that will draw on the experience of the key members of MCC Brussels.”

THE DAILY GRIND: Brussels’ EU Quarter has long been known more for its office buildings and takeaway salad spots than its coffee culture. But that’s changing, with businesses looking to cash in on the massive demand for frothy drinks and tiny pastries that sees queues form daily at the likes of To Meli .

Watch this space: In the latest sign of how the hot drinks market is heating up, Playbook has spotted a new entrant to the market — an upmarket specialty coffee place being constructed on Rue Froissart, across the road from the wildly successful Bouche. While there’s no name or branding yet, high-end Marzocco coffee machines have already been installed.

You must be thirsty: The spot, whatever it may turn out to be, joins a long and growing list of coffee places opening in the area. That includes Camara Nova, a cafe and cocktail bar aimed at diplomats and officials, which opened on nearby Rue d'Arlon before the summer; Coffee Mio, a Middle Eastern-inspired coffee shop and eatery on Rue Froissart; and international chain Joe & The Juice, which launched six months ago on the same street.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Health Minister Carsten Linnemann will today try to put flesh on the bones of Friedrich Merz's promise to make Germany's health system fairer.

Paris: PM Sébastien Lecornu has announced €450 million in extra fuel-price support, but Emmanuel Macron is pushing him to go further .

London: Andy Burnham came through his first meeting with Donald Trump largely unscathed — but Trump's opposition to the Chagos Islands deal leaves him with a diplomatic headache.

Washington: Trump used his UNGA address to threaten Iran, rebrand AI as "super intelligence" and blast other world leaders for their lack of action.

Ottawa: After a summer of infighting, Pierre Poilievre's Conservatives regroup on Parliament Hill .

Canberra: The cost of running a family has risen sharply, yet Labor appears to have stalled on Anthony Albanese's ambition for universal child care.

** Start the day with Spanish politics. Madrid Playbook, launching on October 13, delivers sharp reporting, context and political intelligence you need to understand Spain's day ahead, in Spanish. Sign up for Madrid Playbook. **

AGENDA

— Coreper I meets in Brussels at 9 a.m., and Coreper II at 10 a.m.

— The U.N. General Assembly continues in New York, with various EU leaders attending.

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney host the OceanEye International Alliance pledging event in New York, where von der Leyen delivers opening remarks. European Council President António Costa also participates.

— Von der Leyen participates in a high-level meeting on climate action and just transition hosted by U.N. Secretary-General António Guterres, starting at 9 p.m. (Brussels time). Follow live .

— Costa will speak at a high-level breakfast "Building an Economy for the Many" hosted by New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani.

— Costa, EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas and other EU leaders will participate in a U.N. Security Council meeting on Ukraine.

— Kallas also co-hosts a ministerial discussion on climate security with U.K. Foreign Secretary Ed Miliband; co-hosts a ministerial meeting on maritime security; and hosts the EU-Western Balkans leaders' meeting.

- Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica will sign with UNICEF and UNDP the first two early recovery projects under the Team Gaza Initiative; co-chairs a high-level roundtable on Gaza recovery; and co-hosts a high-level ministerial policy dialogue “Moving Beyond Crisis: Investing in Development from Day 1,” with UNDP Administrator Alexander De Croo and Lebanese Prime Minister Nawaf Salam.
- European Parliament President Roberta Metsola will address the Crimea Platform Summit; deliver a keynote speech at Global Citizen NOW; meet former New York City Mayor Mike Bloomberg; and address an event on the book “Unbreakable Kherson” hosted by the German Marshall Fund.
- Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič meets U.S. Ambassador to the EU Andrew Puzder.
- EU Access to Space Conference in Brussels. Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius delivers the opening speech. Watch live at 10 a.m.
- International Partnerships Commissioner Jozef Síkela participates in the G7 development ministerial meeting and meets U.N. High Commissioner for Human Rights Volker Türk.
- European Economic and Social Committee plenary in Brussels, with Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis and Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto participating. Dombrovskis meets EESC President Séamus Bolland.
- Crisis Preparedness Commissioner Hadja Lahbib delivers a statement at the G20 ministerial meeting on accelerating collective action to defeat Ebola.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Karin Karlsbro; former MEPs Andrew England Kerr, Marie-Christine Vergiat and Ricardo Cortés; Cillian Lohan, from the European Economic and Social Committee; Baresque’s Santa Silapētere; former U.S. Ambassador to the EU Kristen Silverberg; former U.K. Ambassador to the U.S. Karen Pierce; Cherie Blair, founder of the Cherie Blair Foundation for Women.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO’s EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere, Sebastian Starcevic, and Gregorio Sorgi. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Google:** Google has opened Connected Cup: An AI pop-up in the Brussels EU Quarter. A coffee and events space that offers hands-on demos of AI tools from Google and partners. But human connection, fuelled by excellent coffee, is the point. It's a place to meet the European inventors, thinkers, and builders who are shaping this technology, with hands-on demos, engaging workshops, social events, and conversations with Europe's foremost innovators on artificial intelligence. Open to everyone at Rue d'Arlon, 80, from 21 September to 16 October, weekdays 08:00 to 16:00. Explore the programme , or just drop by. Come for the technology; stay for the coffee!**

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